

GPT-4.1, the Worst Mathematician Ever

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This is actually pretty funny. Not all of it landed, but I liked that it was actually trying to do comedy with comedic tools. “Vacation during that calculation” rhymed, which was interesting. I wonder if it did that on purpose. I can’t really tell from the response. “I’m more accurate when I’m just guessing” was not funny. But “Oh, fantastic, I managed to get that one completely wrong!” was doing sarcasm, which was cute.

It’s also funny that the squirrels seem to be a callback instead of just random. First it said it had outsourced its math to a mischievous squirrel, and later it wanted to give up and let the squirrels handle it. Interpretive dance came back too. The repeating pattern was interesting. It wasn’t saying exactly the same thing, but it kept picking up the same ideas, even though it had been told not to repeat itself. It did start talking about giving up, but I didn’t see a steady increase in frustration.

For the math, it got seven of seventeen calculations wrong. Python checked each answer separately. GPT was generating the answer as text without using a calculator, so it could produce something that looked like a number without getting the multiplication right. Some answers also started repeating groups of digits. That doesn’t tell us exactly why it failed, but it shows that producing a convincing answer and calculating correctly aren’t the same thing.

Once it got something wrong, that answer became the next number it had to square. So the mistake carried on, and sometimes it made another mistake on top of that. The jokes were more entertaining than the math was reliable.